

Bass Head

A big all-valve bass amp and an 8×10 cabinet, with a gate, a tuner and a clean DI blend.



Overview

Bass Head is an all-valve bass amp in the spirit of the classic 300-watt heads, driving a sealed 8×10 cabinet. The preamp valve is clean and round when GAIN is low and starts to growl as you turn it up. The tone stack has bass and treble shelves, a midrange control with five frequencies, and two voicing switches: ULTRA LO for a deep low end with scooped mids, and ULTRA HI for extra top.

MASTER sets how hard the push-pull power stage works. Low settings give clean headroom; higher settings bring in the sag of the power supply, compression and the output transformer's saturation - the big-amp feel when you dig in. After the amp, the cabinet can be switched out for a line-out sound, and a clean DI signal can be blended in underneath, as engineers often do with a real bass rig.

The amp works in mono, as a real amp does: the two inputs are added together, and both outputs carry the amp. It runs at twice the sample rate inside to keep the distortion clean. The valves' bias wanders very slightly over time, so the sound is never quite static.

Reach for it for

- DI'd bass guitar that needs the weight and growl of an amp

- Clean, round valve tone for fingerstyle and pick playing
- Driven, growling rock bass (GAIN and MASTER up)
- Blending amp and DI for definition and low end together
- Synth bass that needs a bit of amp character

Controls

The control panel

BASS, MIDRANGE and TREBLE move in 0.5 dB steps; hold Shift to move them freely. Double-click a knob to reset it.

GAIN	The preamp valve, 0 to 10 (4 by default). Low settings are clean and round; as you turn it up the valve starts to growl and distort.
ULTRA LO	A deep low-end lift (about +4 dB around 40 Hz) together with a scooped midrange (about -10 dB around 500 Hz). The classic big, hollow modern bass sound.
ULTRA HI	A bright top-end lift, about +8 dB from 8 kHz up. Adds click and string noise.
BASS	A low shelf at 80 Hz, -12 to +12 dB.
MIDRANGE	Boost or cut at the FREQUENCY set beside it, -12 to +12 dB. Boost for a bass that cuts through a busy mix; cut for a smoother, deeper tone.
FREQUENCY	Where MIDRANGE works: 220 Hz, 450 Hz, 800 Hz, 1.6 kHz or 3 kHz (450 Hz by default). Click a value to choose it, or click / drag / use the mouse wheel on the knob to step through. In the flat look this knob is called FREQ.
TREBLE	A high shelf at 5 kHz, -12 to +12 dB.
MASTER	How hard the push-pull power stage is driven, 0 to 10 (4 by default). Low settings stay clean with plenty of headroom; higher settings add the sag of the power supply, compression and the output transformer's saturation.

The lower strip

GATE	A noise gate before the amp, from OFF (fully down, -80 dB) up to -20 dB. Raise it until the hum and buzz between notes disappear but the notes still ring out.
TUNER	Switches the tuner on. While it is on the output is muted, so you can tune silently. It reads notes from about 35 to 700 Hz. The display shows the note and octave, with a dot that moves left (flat) or right (sharp); the note turns green when you are within 4 cents. It reads PLAY A NOTE until it hears a clear pitch, and TUNER OFF when switched off.
CAB	The 8×10 cabinet in or out (in by default). Out gives the amp's line-out sound, for use with a cabinet simulator of your own.
MIC	The microphone on the cabinet, 0 to 10 (3 by default): from on axis (brighter, with more of the cone's bite) to off axis (darker and softer). Only heard with CAB in.
DI BLEND	Mixes the clean DI signal in under the amp, 0 to 100%. 0% is amp only; 100% is the clean DI only. The DI keeps a solid, clear low end while the amp provides the growl.
OUTPUT	The final level, -24 to +12 dB.
LEVEL	Ten lights showing the output level, green up to amber and red at the top.

The header

Pilot lamp	Shows the amp is on. It takes the theme's accent colour.
Theme picker	Changes the colour of the control panel, its pinstripe and the pilot lamp. Graphite (the default) keeps the aluminium panel with a blue stripe and lamp.
HW	Switches between the hardware-style head and the flat look.

S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window.
?	Next to the S / M / L size keys. Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

Tips

- For a classic clean bass, keep GAIN around 3-4 and MASTER low, and shape the tone with BASS and MIDRANGE at 800 Hz.
- For growl that still sits under the mix, push GAIN and MASTER, then bring in 20-40% DI BLEND to keep the low end solid.
- If the bass disappears on small speakers, boost MIDRANGE at 800 Hz or 1.6 kHz rather than adding more BASS.
- Use TUNER before recording: it mutes the output, so you can leave it on while you tune and switch it off to play.
- Set GATE only as high as you need - too high and it will cut off the tail of long notes.

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